

Nation **AMAR SINGH**

Costly DIVORCE

By Priya Sahgal with
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It was the first day of Amar Singh's new life. Awake late at night, watching *The Guns of Navarone*, an old favourite, the flamboyant Thakur was busy meeting well-wishers in the study of his bungalow in Lutyen's Delhi. A visitor walked up to Mulayam Singh Yadav's portrait hanging next to those of Amitabh Bachchan and Anil Ambani, and suggested he replace it. Amar replied with a wry smile, "It's not easy. If I find a suitable replacement I will change the picture." Why not Ram Manohar Lohia, Mahatma Gandhi or Maharana Pratap? Amar seemed more inclined towards former prime minister Chandra Shekhar. Being one who has had a ringside view of replacements in the heartland of Indian politics, he certainly knows that finding a new political orientation—and a new *netaji*—will take more than just changes in interior decoration.

At the Yadav camp too, replacing him would take a dramatic reorientation in the way the party has played its politics for the past 14 years. Since February 1996, the Mulayam-Amar partnership has been the finest example in mutually assured utility. While Mulayam provided the mass base, it was Amar who marketed his leader's grassroots appeal beyond the borders of Uttar Pradesh. It was the Thakur's smarts that ensured national headlines for a regional party. When Mulayam got into trouble over his disproportionate assets case, Amar, the master of backrooms, bailed him out. And it was Mulayam's political clout that was Amar's calling card at Delhi durbar. Together, the socialist and the socialite were a formidable team. It is hard to imagine the feisty Thakur without the wrestler from Etawah.

Yet, for the last six months, it was

clear that this rather odd couple was headed for political splitsville. Mulayam's family began to blame him for all that was wrong in the Samajwadi Party (SP). Amar retaliated on his well-read blog. Forced to choose between his family and his best friend, Mulayam chose the former. On February 2, Amar, along with his "guided missile" and party MP Jaya Prada, was expelled. Four Amar-loyal MLAs were suspended. No action was taken against the other Jaya, even though Jaya Bachchan had said that she would choose family over party. And Amar Singh is 'family'.

When Mulayam called to wish his erstwhile lieutenant on his birthday on January 27, Amar asked for an unusual gift. "As a parting gift, I asked for expulsion. I did not want to be the one to



LIFE WITHOUT AMAR SINGH

- Amitabh Bachchan will no longer campaign for him with his family in tow.
- No more photo-ops with global stars. Next time the Clintons come calling, Mulayam may not be invited for tea.
- Unlikely to find another well-connected fundraiser.
- No more soundbite-rich press conferences in the Capital with take-away lunch boxes.